

UNITED FACE Supriya Sule, Uddhav Thackeray, Sharad Pawar and Sanjay Raut at Pawar's Mumbai home

WHAT'S FUELLING SPECULATIONS OF AN NCP SPLIT?

- While opposition parties aggressively sought a JPC probe in Parliament into the allegations against the Adani Group, Sharad Pawar opposed the demand
- Ajit Pawar's palace coup in 2019 saw him join hands with the BJP in a short-lived arrangement that preceded the formation of the MVA govt
- ED did not name Ajit and his wife Sunetra in a chargesheet in a case about a sugar mill's auction at an undervalued price
- There are conjectures that Ajit and some of his loyal MLAs may join forces with the BJP to evade action from the central investigating agencies
- If CM Shinde and 15 of his MLAs are disqualified in the event of an SC order, the BJP may need to shore up its numbers in the legislature
- The two Pawars have defended PM Modi after the opposition sought details about his educational qualifications
- Opposition parties, including the NCP, raised doubts about the alleged tampering of EVMs, but Ajit virtually gave the machines a clean chit

to ensure more seats in our kitty from Maharashtra in the Lok Sabha polls as our party's central leadership is focused on ensuring a good showing nationally," claims one leader. The other BJP leader says some developments are likely to take place before the Lok Sabha election. "They are willing to join us anytime, but we will give them the signal at the right moment," he maintains. When contacted by INDIA TODAY, Sule said: "I have absolutely no knowledge of it."

A senior Congress leader from western Maharashtra, where the NCP also has a base, says instead of playing a secondary role in an alliance with the BJP, Ajit also seems to be exploring the option of continuing with the MVA in the hope that the NCP will emerge as the single-largest party in the assembly polls next year. This may help him make a bid for the CM's post, a job that eluded him in 2004 despite the NCP having 71 seats—two more than those won by their ally, the Congress. At that time, it was seen as a move by Pawar to cut his nephew to size.

As a source from the ranks of Thackeray's Shiv Sena notes, the supporters of the NCP, which has a largely rural and peri-urban base, are pragmatic and may migrate with their leaders to greener pastures. Many leaders from the NCP and Congress, like revenue minister Radhakrishna Vikhe-Patil (Congress) and former deputy chief minister Vijaysinh Mohite Patil and his son Ranjitsinh (NCP), have made a successful transition to the BJP over the years.

NCP chief spokesperson Mahesh Tapase has denied any contentions of a split in the party. "In the recent session of the state legislature, Ajit Pawar aggressively played the part of the leader of the Opposition. (Sharad) Pawar Saheb will attend the MVA's joint rally in Mumbai on May 1. He is also trying to unify the Opposition at the national level (for the 2024 Lok Sabha polls). Ajit Pawar is one of the main generals in this fight (against the BJP)," he says. On his part, deputy chief minister Fadnavis has admitted that some legislators from the Congress and NCP are in touch with them.

The speculations over the NCP's next moves have also brought 82-year-old Pawar's politics into focus. Pawar is described as unpredictable even by contemporary political standards. Fadnavis has earlier said that in 2019, the BJP was in power-sharing talks with Pawar himself before his early morning swearing-in with Ajit.

Senior journalist Vijay Chormare, who has covered Pawar's politics at close quarters, says while a political motive is being attributed to Pawar's statement on the Adani issue, the ties between Pawar and Adani are decades old. He adds the statements on Modi's degree, however, have "caused damage to the NCP's reputation like in 2014, when the party had offered support to the BJP. This was a major blunder, but some calculations must be behind this move."

According to Chormare, the speculation about Ajit's course of action arose from the SC's impending judgment. "Such rumour-mongering is unjust," he says. However, senior journalist and editor Nikhil Wagle says Ajit could go to the BJP's side "in whatever form, either as part of the NCP or as a rebel" if he is promised the CM's position. Pawar Senior "will remain in the opposition alliance and yet help Modi and the BJP as he has always maintained his relations across party lines," he adds.

As a former Congress minister notes, the hypothesis that the united MVA could pool its strength and take on the Shinde-BJP combine and emerge triumphant had been proven in the by-polls to the Kasba Peth constituency in Pune—a saffron stronghold. Here, Ravindra Dhangekar of the Congress scored a victory over Hemant Rasane of the BJP. "When senior BJP leaders say they have taken a lesson from this defeat, it is obvious they will work to splinter the united opposition," he says. Whether the NCP and the larger MVA manage to withstand these pressures and stay together may determine the outcome of Maharashtra's politics in the days to come. ■